Air pollution vs. inflation

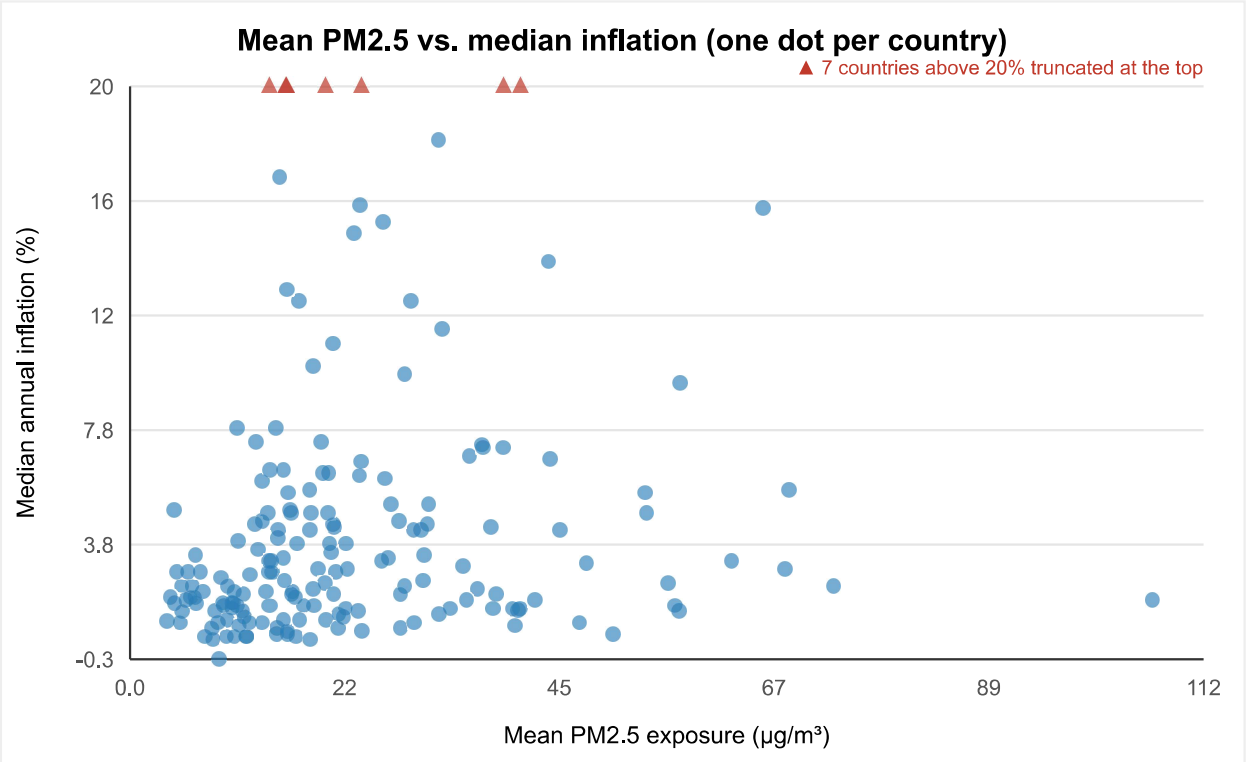
Generated 2026-10-15T05:07:49+00:00 from the curated dataset (1583 country-year rows, 181 countries, 2015–2023).

> **Key insight.** Across 178 countries, mean PM2.5 exposure and median inflation show a weak positive rank correlation (Spearman ρ = +0.28). The relationship is a statistical association, not evidence that one drives the other.

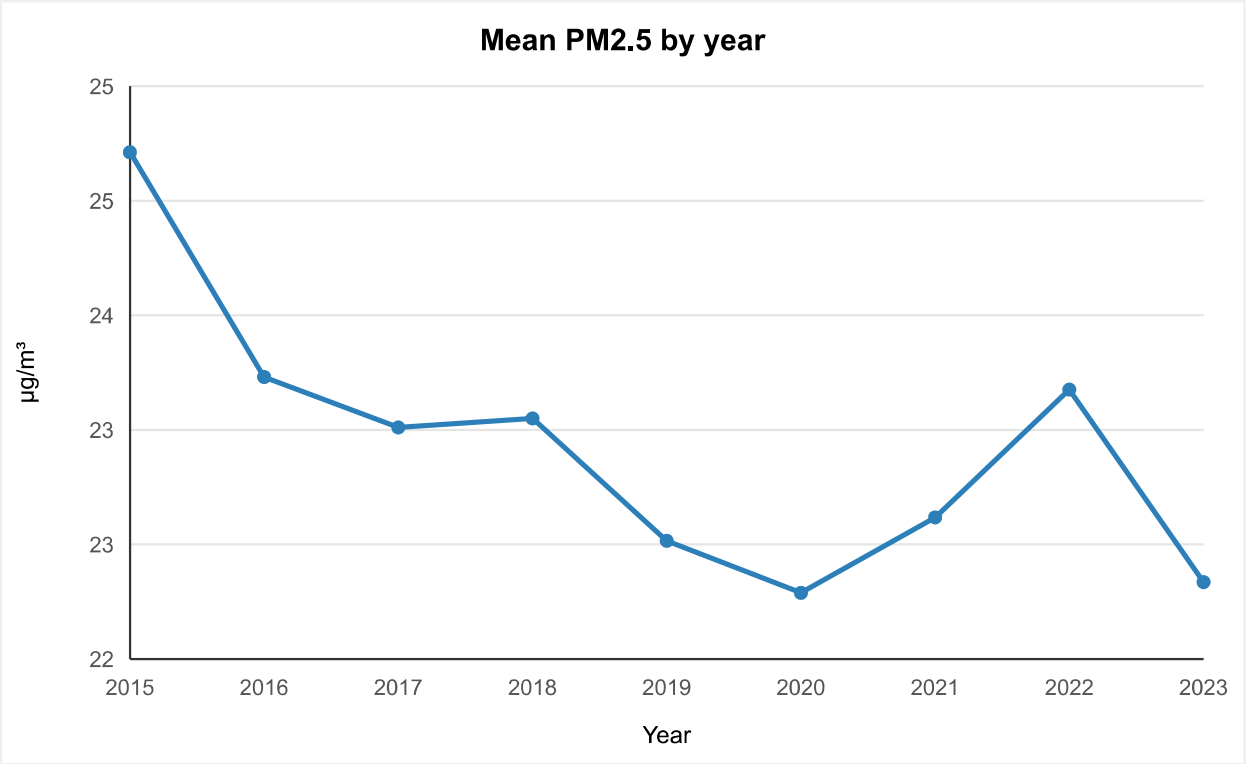
Correlation across countries

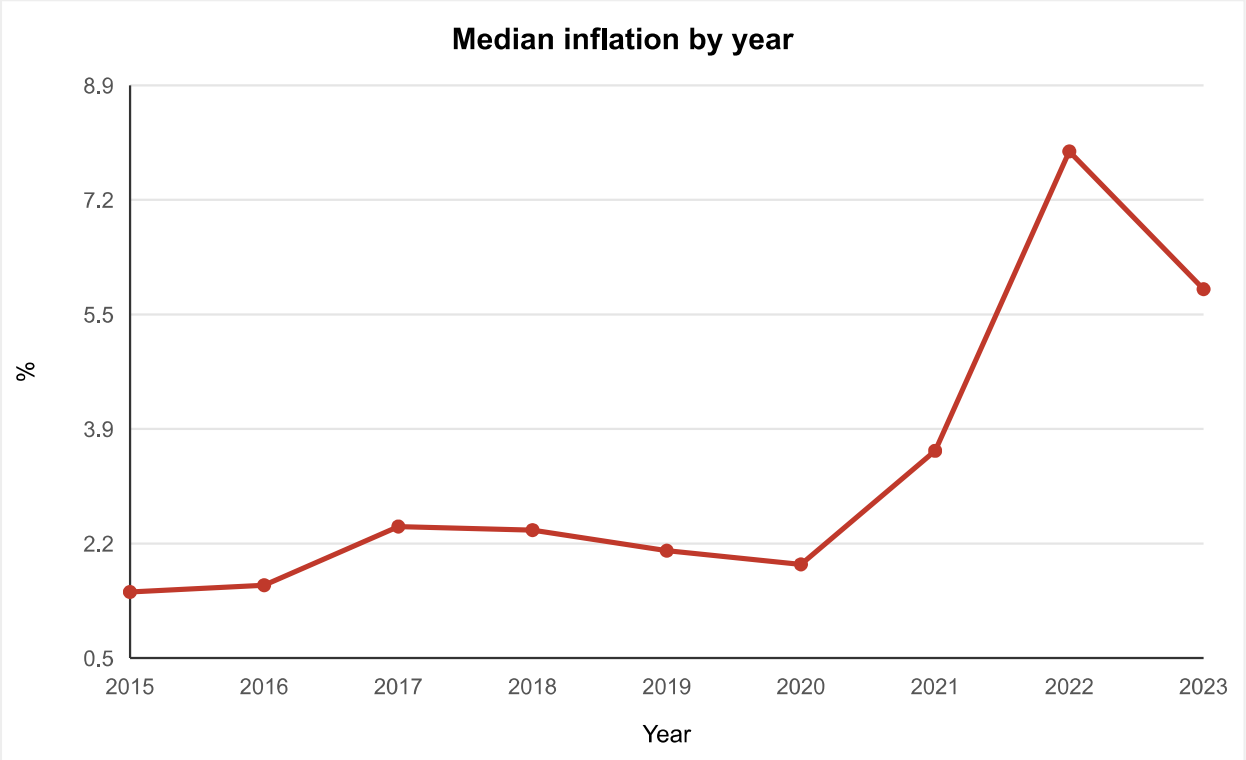
Metric	Value
Spearman (rank) correlation	+0.28
Pearson correlation	+0.08
Countries in the calculation	178

Each country is summarised by its mean PM2.5 and median inflation over the years available (min. 3). Spearman is the primary metric because inflation has extreme outliers.



Trend over time





Year	Countries	Mean PM2.5 (µg/m³)	Median inflation (%)
2015	180	24.83	1.5
2016	180	23.58	1.6
2017	178	23.3	2.45
2018	177	23.35	2.4
2019	177	22.67	2.1
2020	174	22.38	1.9

Year	Countries	Mean PM2.5 (µg/m³)	Median inflation (%)
2021	174	22.8	3.55
2022	173	23.51	7.9
2023	170	22.44	5.9

By income group

Income group	Countries	Mean PM2.5 (µg/m³)	Median inflation (%)
High income	60	17.66	1.7
Upper middle income	54	20.94	3.2
Lower middle income	44	29.28	4.9
Low income	20	32.31	7.2

By region (ranked by PM2.5)

Region	Countries	Mean PM2.5 (µg/m³)	Median inflation (%)
Middle East, North Africa, Afghanistan & Pakistan	22	40.66	2.05
South Asia	6	40.48	5.25
Sub-Saharan Africa	44	29.77	4.8
Latin America & Caribbean	31	17.05	3.4
East Asia & Pacific	26	16.16	1.95
Europe & Central Asia	47	15.2	2.1
North America	2	7.19	2.0

Caveats

Correlation is not causation: both indicators track country development and size. Country-level figures are unweighted by population. Only countries present in both sources (matched by ISO3 code) and with enough overlapping years are included.